

ICE CLIMBING IN EUROPE

By Kat Nickola

For all those rock climbers or winter hikers out there ready to stretch their skills, Europe is a great place to start ice climbing.

Your goal is simple enough: climb up a cliff made of ice. But, in this winter sport the conditions can vary year-to-year and even day-to-day. That is because the ice that you are climbing is formed seasonally. Often, an ice fall will develop in places where water slowly trickles from cracks in a cliff. Over the season it will change as more water emerges from the ground to trickle down, solidify and build the ice flow. Sometimes entire waterfalls freeze and can be climbed, while in other places you can climb the edges of glaciers.

The sport of ice climbing is comparable to rock climbing, in that you will use a harness, rope and helmet for safety. Beyond that, the gear is a bit different. You have two small, specially designed ice axes—one for each hand—to grip the ice and stabilize yourself while climbing upward. It is also necessary to wear rigid mountaineering boots with C3 crampons. These are very stiff and have multi-directional spikes to help grasp the ice, including forward-facing spikes at the toe to help you get a foothold for moving up. Lastly, you will need appropriate cold-weather clothes. Dress in layers and use an outer shell jacket and side-zip pants that can handle some abrasion against the ice. ■

Where to learn

Newbies looking for lessons can find outfitters and guides at the major ice climbing hubs across Europe. These hotspots are also perfect for seasoned ice climbers.



Les Ecrins, France



Europe's highest concentration of ice climbs are in the mountains of the Parc National des Écrins. This section of the French Alps is full of canyons and valleys where the waterflows consistently freeze every year. There is also a big annual ice festival at the end of January in the Freissinières Valley with exhibitions, competitions and plenty of workshops. Festivals are a great way to learn about the sport, try out some gear and take a class to help you learn ice climbing skills.

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Ötztal, Austria

There are so many places to ice climb in Austria that it makes for an easy day trip to add to any winter skiing holiday. Almost every ski resort or hotel can connect you with a tour or mountain guide ready to take you on the ice. For the most options and an ice-focused trip, head to the Ötztal (Ötz Valley) west of Innsbruck. Between the villages of Längenfeld and Sölden there are dozens of frozen waterfalls just waiting to be climbed.

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Dolomites, Italy

It seems like the Dolomites are a hotspot for every mountain sport, and ice climbing is no exception. The tall spires and high alpine waterfalls make perfect ice falls ready for climbers once the freezing season begins. The Val Gardena area is surrounded with ice climbing options. There are high, exposed routes on rock faces, but also deep, intimate spaces in hidden valleys.

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Saas-Fee, Switzerland

There is a reason the Ice Climbing World Cup is held in Saas-Fee every year. This spot offers the unique experience of climbing the edge of a glacier, with routes for beginners and advanced climbers spanning this long icy cliff. There are also two other public ice climbing parks where they 'farm' ice to create an artificial ice wall: the Ice Climbing Dome and the Ice Tower in Kalbermatten.

GATE CLOSES 15 MINUTES BEFORE



Rjukan, Norway

For guaranteed ice and frozen temperatures, Norway is your destination. Rjukan is one of the most popular ice climbing destinations in the world. This small village is nestled at the bottom of a steep valley, meaning it doesn't get direct sunlight for months in the winter. Because of this, the ice climbing season lasts significantly longer, from November to March, than at ice walls in the Alps. There are over 190 frozen waterfalls that line the sides of the valley, meaning you can get to climbs quickly, spend a cold (short) day on the ice and be back in town in no time.

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